Dear Sara Jane

By Victor Lodato

A young woman next to a small table. On the table is a human skull, a letter and perhaps a framed mirror. The woman begins the scene regarding the skull, she stares and stares at it. Finally, she speaks to the audience. She is emotionally agitated, but attempts to appear casual, composed – even lighthearted.

SARA JANE: *[Trembling, she picks up the letter from the table, reads]* ***Dear Sara Jane . . .***

Dear Sara Jane. That's me. Sara Jane. My husband's Jerry. Jerry sent me this. Jerry sent me this skull. In a box.

Dear Sara Jane. That's me. ***I did not kill him. He was already dead. When we found him, I took his head with my own knife. Not easy. I boiled it down, scraped it, then boiled it again. It is bleached and so it is clean, don't worry. We will keep it. It is terrible but we are winning. I will be home soon.***

Who loves you? Do you know? Jerry. Jerry. And Jerry. *[puts down the letter, her hands still shaking]*

INTRODUCTION

The Dalai Lama once said: "War is neither glamorous nor attractive. It is monstrous. Its very nature is one of tragedy and suffering." Today it seems as if most of our world is mired in armed conflict: Sudan, Haiti, Gaza, Ukraine – The list seems endless as troops are deployed.

So imagine . . . Your loved one is fighting in a far-away war -- A war with atrocities you can only imagine. When and if they return home, will they be the same person; or will the war have changed them in brutal and irreversible ways? This is the question plaguing the wife of Jerry Housetree in . . .

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SARA JANE: I love my husband. Jerry. I do. Green eyes. With little bits of copper in them. And his hair, his hair is this wonderful color. Cinnamon. And this deep voice. It rumbles. Rumbles. Makes you melt. And big, big beautiful hands. And they're always

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warm. Mine are always cold. Ice. Even in the summer. He must be sweating over there. Cause it's so hot where he is. Very hot. I worry about him. It hardly seems real. All of this. I don't like to watch it. On the television. I turned it on once, and there was this picture, this, this image. Oh, I mean half of what you see is probably not even true. I'm not going to let my children watch it. Not too much anyway. Jerry and I don't have kids yet. We're gonna though. Two or three. He says two. I saw this image. Children running. And it looked like the street was a river. Of blood. Some of the children were bleeding. Some children were dragging other children. Trying to carry them. Maybe they were dead, I don't know, you couldn't tell. And the screaming was like birds -- I've never heard screaming like that. Like a singing, a siren. And the street like a river. And they were running. And I kept thinking, shoes of blood. Couldn't get that out of my head. Shoes of blood, shoes of blood, shoes of blood. *[a nervous giggle]* Just spinning. Around and around.

I read in the newspaper about this one village -- it was all women and children, just like they say in the movies, you know, to make it very dramatic, women and children -- and they were all killed. Burned. Well, you know, they say even the children are setting traps in the woods. That these children, from a very early age, are taught these things -- how to set these horrible traps that can kill a man. I'm not saying these children in this village were killers. I'm not saying that. I talked to my mother about it. Because I was confused, I was upset. She said: 'Honey, innocent people always die in a war, that's just the way it is. In a war.' And that word! Is it a war, isn't it a war. Oh, my god. They don't stop with that. A *war.*

I don't really understand the whole thing. You know? I don't get it. This house, it's a beautiful house we live in. We've only been here six months. There's a swing set out back. Rusty, but Jerry says he can fix it up. He's an ace at fixing cars. That's what he was doing. Before he left. He's going back to school when he comes home. He will come home. We're just a couple of miles from the community college. We don't know what he's going to study. Restaurant management, I

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thought. Oh, I would love to open a restaurant one day. Jerry's not sure. Maybe hotel management, he says. He's smart. He is. You wouldn't think it at first. But he is. He's quick. He's funny. Oh, my god, is he funny. Makes everybody laugh. I mean, how could a person maintain even a basic level of sanity in the middle of all that? All that blood.

And snakes, there's snakes, you know, everywhere. And the screaming.

And explosions. Something happens to your mind. Something must have happened to Jerry's mind to do something like this. Running around in the woods. Not the woods, that's not what they call it. The jungle. I'm not going to pretend a person could maintain their manners in the middle of something like that. In the middle of a *jungle.* In the middle of a *war.*

[looks at the skull, touches the eye sockets] This is where the eyes were. One here. And one here. Little eyes. Slanty eyes. And there was a brain in here. And skin. Tongue. Lips. Just like a regular person. Eyebrows. Hair. Ears. He did it all himself. Jerry. Cleaned it up. All of it. Yes, he did. Oh, my god. And he did a good job, didn't he? He's an ace at cars. With his hands.

I love my husband. I do.

I mean, how do you ever really know another person? Really know them. I have secrets. Sure I do. Even from Jerry. I have dreams. I have ideas. Things you'd be embarrassed to say. But you know what? When Jerry comes home, I'm gonna tell him everything. Everything. I'm not gonna be embarrassed to tell him anything. And I want him to tell me everything. I mean, my god, how could he? Because two people should tell each other shouldn't they? They should tell each other every little thing.

So there's nothing between them. Because doesn't it feel sometimes there's a life inside you and it's trying to come out, it's trying to find its way out. So you have to

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talk about these things. Where have we been? Where are we going? Because you don't want to get lost. I want to have everything in order. Everything in order. When Jerry comes home. Because that's when our life starts, doesn't it?

I just wish I could fall asleep. That's the thing. Just a few hours of sleep. *[pause]* It's so quiet in the house. Oh my god, it's so quiet. *[looks at the skull]* And this one -- this one -- says nothing.

Who loves you? Do you know? Take a guess. Jerry. Jerry. And Jerry. *[looks at the audience]* I'm so scared. I'm so scared. I'm so scared.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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